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MEMORIAL DAY - Southland salutes and thanks the fallen - Some gatherings marking military sacrifice return after years of pandemic hiatus

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On Memorial Day, familiar events put on hold or forced online by the coronavirus pandemic returned for the first time in three years, while entirely new ceremonies were launched as well, all to honor military men and women who made the ultimate sacrifice in defense of their nation.

The first public event for Memorial Day at the Los Angeles National Cemetery since 2019 was held, with Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass among the speakers.

Bass recognized the service of fallen military members and discussed how the public can do more to serve veterans in need on a morning that also featured remarks by Maj. Gen. Evan Dertian, the commander of the Air Force Test Center at Edwards Air Force Base, music by the 300th Army Band, and displays by buffalo soldier and Civil War reenactors.

More than 200 people gathered

Sunday as Long Beach debuted its “Sunset Ceremony — Honoring Our Heroes” event, the first major activity to be organized by the city’s Office of Veterans Support, which was established Oct. 1.

The event was held at the Long Beach Navy Memorial in Shoreline Aquatic Park, 200 Aquarium Way, a site that commemorates the 90-year history of the Navy in Long Beach and features the Navysphere, a 15-foot sculpture of a sphere by local artist Terry Braunstein, who also spoke on remembering those who gave their lives for the United States.

Excitement tinged with bittersweet emotion was part of the experience for paradegoers and participants at the 31st Canoga Park Memorial Day Parade, which returned to Sherman Way for the first time in three years.

Memorial Day is dedicated to honoring and remembering the men and women who died during active service in the United States military, and deceased veterans who served at any time abroad or at home.

This year's parade, with the theme “Saluting the Price of Freedom,” included Sun Valley’s North Valley Military Institute Color Guard, bands from Canoga Park and Taft Charter high schools, the Blue Knights International Law Enforcement Motorcycle Club, Boys and Girls Club of the West Valley, and Naval Mobile Construction Battalion 3, based in Port Hueneme.

Elder guest veterans riding in the parade included:

• Ethel Margolin, 101, a WAC who served in World War II.

• Barney Leone, 97, a World War II Navy veteran who served at Iwo Jima, Okinawa, China and the Philippines.

• Joe Weber, 94, a World War II sailor.

• Bill Bird, 92, who served in the 6th Army Special Services from 1952-1954.

• Leon Martinez, 91, an Air Force veteran of the 18th Supply Squadron in Okinawa, Japan and Taiwan from 1952-

1954.

Elected officials who joined in the parade included Los Angeles City Councilmember Bob Blumenfield, Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, Los Angeles Police Chief Michel Moore, Los Angeles Unified School District board member Scott Schmerelson and Rep. Brad Sherman.

A flyover was staged by the 146th Airlift Wing — C-130J, a unit of the California Air National Guard stationed in Oxnard. Also appearing were Navy Seabees, who specialize in construction to support military operations. The unit on hand has built airfields, schools and hospitals and repaired infrastructure.

“The Canoga Park Memorial Day Parade reminds us how important it is to come together as a community and show respect for those who sacrificed their lives for our freedom,” said Miri Rossitto, founder and CEO of Cowe Communications. “It's a powerful event that brings neighbors closer, honors our fallen heroes and underscores that freedom has a price — one that should always be remembered.”

The ceremony included a wreath laying at the Wall of Honor in memory of Air Force 1st Lt. Arthur “Skip” Bedal, a navigator aboard a B-26B Invader who was killed with two other crewman when the bomber slammed into a mountain during a support mission for South Vietnamese troops against the Viet Cong on Aug. 16, 1963.

The crash occurred in the guerrilla-infested jungle of Quang Ngai province in central Vietnam, near the South China Sea. The crash was later attributed to mechanical failure.

Bedal’s daughter Sheryl-Jo Bedal was the parade's Vietnam War honoree. She was 20 months old when her father was killed.

In Simi Valley, the Reagan library’s ceremonies included the Los Angeles County Sheriff Band, a flyover by the Tiger Squadron and remarks from members of Gold Star families and military dignitaries.

The 50th Fiesta Days Parade in La Cañada Flintridge stepped out starting at Cornishon Avenue and then along Foothill Boulevard to Gould Avenue. The theme was “Golden Jubilee.” L.A. County Supervisor Kathryn Barger, whose district includes La Cañada Flintridge, was among the parade's participants.

“As we enjoy the long weekend, I encourage everyone to take a moment to remember our fallen heroes as well as those burdened with the loss of carrying on without their loved ones,” Barger said. “We can also honor the lives of those who did not make it home by fulfilling our commitment to serve the veterans in our community. Every day, we must renew our promise to serve those who have served.”

Barger's colleague on the Board of Supervisors Janice Hahn helped raise the American flag at the Memorial Day Observance at Green Hills Memorial Park in Rancho Palos Verdes.

Torrance City Councilmember Sharon Kalani, who has worked at Green Hills Memorial Park for 17 years, said the purpose of the observance was to honor “those who have served and gave the ultimate sacrifice for our country and our freedom.”

“It's very, very important to us here at Green Hills. That's why we've had such a long-standing tradition,” she said.

Staff and friends of the community on Saturday placed about 8,000 flags at graves, Kalani said.

Memorial Day has a special place in Kalani's heart because her grandfather was a career Navy sailor and her father was in the Army, she said.

“So I grew up really understanding not only the value of the armed services, but the sacrifice that they make,” Kalani said.

The observance included skydivers, a procession of colors, a mounted posse, a civilian and military flyover and a performance by Navy Band Southwest. The keynote speaker was retired Army Col. David W. Sutherland, whose career included being commander of coalition forces in Diyala, Iraq, and being the special assistant to Adm. Michael Mullen when he chaired the Joint Chiefs of Staff.

Nearby, the Honoring Our Fallen Memorial Day Reading of Names — which saluted the more than 7,000 Americans who have fallen in combat and training exercises since the 9/11 attacks, as reported by U.S. Central Command — began at 5:30 a.m. at Rosie the Riveter Park in Long Beach with a bagpiper tribute.

Gold Star families, local active-duty personnel, members of law enforcement and first responders assisted in reading the names of the fallen in order of death as inscribed on the park's memorial wall.

Up the coast, San Pedro’s festive, five-day Fleet Week was scheduled to conclude with an evening Memorial Day service at the Main Expo on the waterfront.

Archbishop José H. Gomez presided over an outdoor Memorial Day Mass at San Fernando Mission Cemetery in Mission Hills.

Meanwhile, across the country, the San Pedro High School marching band performed in Washington, D.C., as part of the annual Memorial Day parade that takes place in the nation’s capitol.

The Pirates, part of Los Angeles Unified School District, were supposed to be part of the parade three years ago, but the band’s participation was nixed because of the pandemic.

A ceremony preceding the Los Angeles Dodgers-Washington Nationals game at Dodger Stadium was set to include 30 veterans, active duty service members and first responders making an honor lap around the warning track on bicycles, and a recognition for the 1st Battalion, 9th Marines, which served in Vietnam.

As at all Monday’s major league games, all on-field personnel were scheduled to wear the traditional memorial red poppy patch on the left side of their jerseys with “Lest We Forget” language included, and there was to be a brief moment of silence before the singing of the national anthem.

At South Pasadena's War Memorial Building, an event included the Boy Scout Troop 333 color guard, the national anthem sung by Miranda Miller, music from the Los Angeles County Sheriff’s Department Band and remarks from keynote speaker Brock Milhorn, a Navy veteran and peer support specialist with Veteran Peer Access Network.

Other ceremonies around Los Angeles County were held at Hawaiian Gardens City Hall, Lancaster Cemetery, Lacy Park in San Marino, Veterans Park in Lomita, Whittier City Hall, Acton Community Center, Cerritos Civic Center, Joshua Memorial Park in Lancaster, Paramount City Hall, Veterans Memorial Fountain in South Gate, Veterans Memorial Plaza in Pico Rivera, Veterans Park in Bell Gardens, Avalon Municipal Cemetery, Inglewood City Hall, Del Valle Park in Lakewood, Wilmington Cemetery, Huntington Park Community Center and Hollywood Post 43 of the American Legion.

In his Memorial Day proclamation, President Joe Biden proclaimed Monday as a day of prayer for permanent peace, designating 11 a.m. in each time zone as a point during which people may unite in prayer, citing a 1950 joint resolution by Congress.

Biden also asked all Americans to observe the National Moment of Remembrance beginning at 3 p.m. in each time zone under a bill signed into law in 2000 by then-President Bill Clinton. It was first held on Memorial Day in 2000 under a proclamation by Clinton in an attempt “to reclaim Memorial Day as the noble event it was intended to be, to honor those who died in service to our nation.”

The Moment of Remembrance is a “way we can all help put the memorial back in Memorial Day,” said its founder, Carmella LaSpada.

Biden's proclamation also requested that governors of all U.S. states and territories and the appropriate officials of all units of government direct that the flag be flown at half-staff until noon Memorial Day on all buildings, grounds and naval vessels throughout nation and in all areas under its jurisdiction and control.

Biden also requested the American public display the flag at half-staff from their homes until noon Monday.

“On Memorial Day, we honor America's beloved daughters and sons who gave their last full measure of devotion to this nation,” Biden declared in his proclamation. “We can never fully repay the debt we owe these fallen heroes.

“But today, we vow to rededicate ourselves to the work for which they gave their lives, and we recommit to supporting the families, caregivers and survivors they left behind.”

What became Memorial Day was first observed May 30, 1868, as Decoration Day, a time for the nation to decorate the graves of the Civil War dead with flowers.

It was established 25 days earlier by Maj. Gen. John Logan, national commander of the Grand Army of the Republic, an organization of veterans who fought for the Union in the Civil War. It is believed that date was chosen because flowers would be in bloom all over the nation.

By the end of the 19th century, Decoration Day ceremonies were being held on May 30 throughout the nation. After World War I, the holiday was changed to honor Americans who died fighting in all wars.

The term Memorial Day was first used in 1882, became more common after World War II and was declared the official name by federal law in 1967.

Memorial Day had been observed May 30 until being moved to the last Monday in May in 1971 under terms of the Uniform Monday Holiday Act, which became law in 1968.

Staff writers Holly Andres, Teresa Liu and Rich Archbold and City News Service reporter Steven Herbert contributed to this report.

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